Chapter 100: PERSONALITY

Leyens, T., Ritz, J., & Hofmans, J. (2024). Personality. In: M. Bal (Ed.), *Encyclopedia of Organizational Psychology*. Edward Elgar, 2024.

Acknowledgments: The first author holds a PhD grant strategic basic research of the Research Foundation Flanders (Fonds Wetenschappelijk Onderzoek ; grant number FWOSB99].

Correspondence concerning this manuscript should be directed to:

Theresa Leyens

Vrije Universiteit Brussel, Pleinlaan 2, 1050 Brussel

Theresa.leyens@vub.be

Note: This paper is not the copy of record and may not exactly replicate the final, authoritative version of the article published in the *Encyclopedia of Organizational Psychology*.

Abstract

More and more organizational research focuses on personality at work, and personality tests have increasingly become part of personnel selection and development procedures. This chapter provides an overview of the current state of research on personality in the workplace. It covers the history of personality research, theoretical perspectives on personality, and the role of personality in employee selection. This chapter also discusses challenges and controversies related to personality assessment and offers suggestions for future research directions, including the need to focus on the dynamic nature of personality and its interaction with situational factors more.

Keywords: personality; personality assessment; Five-Factor Model; HEXACO model; person-situation interactions

PERSONALITY

"The outstanding characteristic of man is his individuality."

– Gordon Allport

What is personality?

Personality is a prominent construct in psychology. It emerged from the work of European psychiatrists such as Freud, Jung, Adler, and Erikson, who placed great emphasis on the notion that all individuals are neurotic and that the primary aim of life is to overcome this neurosis (Hogan & Foster, 2016). Gordon Allport, considered the father of personality psychology by many, established the discipline as an academic field of interest. He referred to personality as "the dynamic organization within the individual of those psychophysical systems that determine his unique adjustments to his environment" (Allport, 1937, p. 48). Despite decades of research and dozens of definitions, however, there is (still) an ongoing debate on what personality exactly entails. Particularly issues regarding the conceptualization of personality (e.g., whether behavioral manifestations represent personality, the number and breadth of factors that personality taxonomies are composed of, and many more) continue to cause disagreement among researchers. In what follows, we will discuss where the field converged, and which issues are still open for discussion.

Why are we so interested in personality (at work)?

Personality has long been a significant topic of study in psychology because it pertains to the essence of human nature. Moreover, because predicting future (work) behavior is a crucial goal of (industrial) psychology, psychologists have spent considerable time studying its predictive validity based on the idea that to understand behavior, one should first and foremost understand the individual. Following this premise, personality traits (i.e., how people generally behave, feel, and think) have been related to a wide range of life and work domains. Particularly for the work setting, meta-analytic research shows that personality is associated with important work

outcomes such as job satisfaction, job performance, leadership, job satisfaction, and counterproductive work behavior (Ritz, 2023).

How can we capture personality most accurately?

Capturing all possible personality attributes is daunting, which is why researchers have looked for ways to parsimoniously represent the many personality attributes that differentiate individuals. Two approaches have stood out: the dimensional or trait approach and the typological approach.

According to the dimensional approach individuals vary in the degree to which they possess different personality characteristics. This approach assumes that personality traits exist alongside a continuum, and that individuals can be placed somewhere on this continuum based on their level of a particular trait. This means that—for extraversion—one is not identified as a pure introvert or a pure extravert but rather takes a position on this continuum relative to the two extremes. The typological approach, in turn, does not treat personality traits as continuous but as categorical in nature. This means that individuals are categorized into distinct groups or personality types. Taking the example of extraversion, the typological approach would label someone as an extravert or an introvert. Evaluating both approaches, decades of research has convincingly shown that the typological approach does not accurately capture the complexity of personality and ignores the fact that individuals may very well fall in-between categories. Further, assuming that personality types are fixed lacks flexibility and neglects individual's development or change across time. Hence, there is widespread scientific agreement that personality should be treated as dimensional rather than categorical in nature. Unfortunately, however, personality measures that categorize people into a small set of personality types are still used by a substantial number of practitioners.

Knowing that personality is dimensional, a subsequent question pertains to the number of dimensions needed to accurately describe it. Throughout the years, two widely accepted frameworks have emerged. The first is the Five-Factor Model (FFM, also referred to as the Big

5) developed by Costa and McCrae (1992). The FFM organizes personality according to five broad domains: Neuroticism (N), Extraversion (E), Openness to Experience (O), Agreeableness (A), and Conscientiousness (C). Importantly, many alternative trait models can also be mapped onto the Five-Factor model structure and the literature on Costa and McCrae's taxonomy is incredibly extensive, making it the most widely investigated personality taxonomy. The second framework that has received increasing interest and support in recent years is the six-factor HEXACO model (Ashton et al., 2014) – consisting of Honestly-Humility (H), Emotionality (E), Extraversion (X), Agreeableness (A), Conscientiousness (C), and Openness to Experience (O). Both the FFM and the HEXACO model are hierarchical in the sense that they consist of broad factors of personality traits, with those broad factors consisting of a collection of more narrow trait facets. Costa and McCrae (1992) state that each of the highest-level domains (Neuroticism, Extraversion, Openness to Experience, Agreeableness, and Conscientiousness) can be broken down into six facets. The authors of the HEXACO taxonomy (Ashton et al., 2014) find 25 facets for their model, four for each dimension as well as an interstitial Altruism facet. Yet, the number of lower-order facets of these taxonomies is still very open to debate, as discussed by Saucier and Goldberg (2003) who talk about the issue of balancing specificity and comprehensiveness. While they acknowledge that measuring facets could potentially enhance predictive validity, they also warn against the greater risk of confusion among researchers with regards to the optimal number of facets as well as difficulties in achieving consensus of what each facet measures. As a point in case, different facet models, such as the 16PF model or the Occupational Personality Questionnaire 32-facet model, are widely used by practitioners in organizations (Woods & Anderson, 2016). This raises the questions of how findings could be generalized while the use of different facet structures may also lead to inconsistent findings.

Personality stability versus change

Traditionally, the field has strongly emphasized the stable nature of personality traits. It is therefore not surprising that the large majority of studies examining the link between personality

and work outcomes relates stable between-person differences in people's personality traits to stable between-person differences in work-related criteria. Despite the fact that the dynamic character of personality was acknowledged already early on (even Allport described personality as a dynamic organization that determines our emotions and behavior, as stated above), research on personality dynamics is a relatively young field of research. In recent years, two types of dynamics have received increasing attention from researchers: personality state fluctuations and personality trait development.

The idea behind the study of state fluctuations is that individuals not only vary in how they generally behave, feel, and think, but that there are also significant fluctuations in these behaviors, feelings, and cognitions within an individual across different situations and over time (Fleeson, 2001)). Such momentary short-term manifestations of one's personality are referred to as personality states, with people enacting different personality states in different situations. Think of a person who is typically highly conscientious (high trait level of conscientiousness) but behaves less conscientious if there is a lot of time pressure at work. Within-person variability then stems from interactions between an individual's personality (e.g., high trait level of conscientiousness) and situational or environmental forces (e.g., time pressure), or internal motives (e.g., wanting to leave work early).

Research on trait change studies how personality traits change throughout the lifespan (Bleidorn et al., 2021). Even though there is a general tendency for traits to develop towards higher maturity (referred to as trait maturation), there are individual differences in the rate, timing, and direction of these trait changes. Moreover, recent research shows that trait change might be subject to volitional control (Hudson & Fraley, 2015). Despite significant progress in this field in recent years, there are still many unanswered questions regarding the specific sources and processes underlying the changes in personality trait levels (Bleidorn et al., 2021).

Some authors have recently argued that, to move the field of personality (dynamics) forward, it is necessary to come up with an integrative approach to personality that

accommodates both stability and change. The Personality Dynamics (PersDyn) model (Sosnowska et al., 2019) is one model that does this by integrating both within-person (i.e., states) and between-person (i.e., traits) differences by means of three model parameters: baseline personality, personality variability, and personality attractor force. The baseline in the PersDyn model is the average level of behavior, affect and cognitions (i.e., the personality trait level), and represents the central point around which an individual's momentary personality states fluctuate over time and across situations. Personality variability refers to the extent to which an individual's thoughts, feelings and behavior fluctuate over time. Personality attractor strength describes the time that it takes a person to return to their baseline after having deviated from it. People with high attractor strength are quick to return to the baseline level, whereas individuals with low attractor strength take more time.

While looking into temporal dynamics and change of personality is valuable and moves the field away from overly simplistic conceptualizations, the dynamic approach also presents a big challenge from a practical perspective because it implies an increased complexity (both in terms of conceptualization and measurement).

Person-Situation debate

The person-situation debate sought to answer the question whether behavior depended more on the subject's personality or the situation. By now, most people agree that behavior is a function of both, including the interaction between person and situation. The very idea that persons and situation interact lies at the basis of the theory of behavioral signatures, which states that personality is expressed in predictable patterns of within-person variability across time and occasions (Mischel & Shoda, 1995). In other words, "individuals are characterized not only by stable individual differences in their overall levels of behavior, but also by distinctive and stable patterns of behavior variability across situations" (Mischel & Shoda, 1995, p. 246). Acknowledging such person-situation interactions, research shows that contextualizing personality assessment items by simply referring to the situational circumstances (i.e., simply

adding "at work" to traditional personality items; hence "I am talkative at work" instead of "I am talkative") already results in an improvement of the predictive validity of personality measures on job performance (Shaffer & Postlethwaite, 2012). Further, research on so called situation contingencies, or individual differences in the responsiveness of one's personality states to changes in work-related demands, demonstrates that also at the more micro-level person-situation interactions matter and materialize in important work outcomes (e.g., Beckmann & Wood, 2020). With increasingly vague and impermanent work circumstances, employees are increasingly expected to cope appropriate with rapidly shifting demands. Examining situational contingencies at work may therefore lead to a clearer understanding of the requirements and opportunities in workers' adaptive skills.

Measuring personality

One of the main reasons why (work) psychologists have been interested in personality for such a long time, is the goal of being able to predict future (work) behavior. This implies the assessment of personality, based on which predictions can be made. In terms of assessment, important issues to consider are the bandwidth of the instrument and which rater perspective(s) to include.

The bandwidth of an instrument refers to the breadth of its content. For personality assessment, this is the scope of affective, behavioral, and cognitive tendencies that are being measured. Different personality assessment tools differ drastically in this regard. For the FFM, for example, the NEO-PI-R measures the five broad traits alongside 30 facets (six per trait), the Big Five Inventory 2 (BFI-2) measures the five broad traits alongside 15 facets (three per trait), and the TIPI measures only the five broad traits without any facet-level information[1]. Because bandwidth and length of the instrument are related, one needs to thoroughly reflect on the

[1] For more information on the NEO Personality Inventory, Revised (NEO-PI-R) refer to Costa & McCrae, 1992b, 2008. Soto & John (2017) provide more details about the BFI-2, and Gosling et al., (2003) developed the Ten-Item Personality Inventory (TIPI), a very brief FFM instrument.

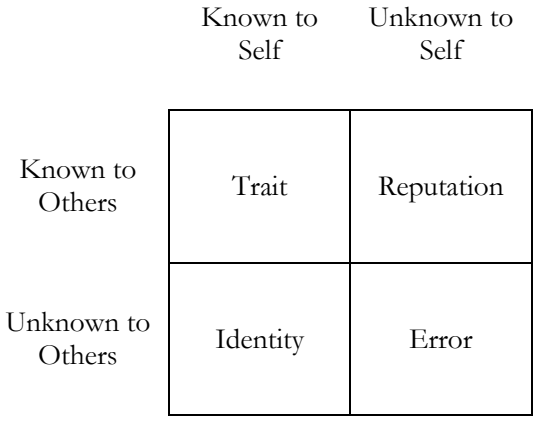
usefulness of the additional information gained by focusing not only on broad traits but also on facet-level information. In this regard, meta-analytic research shows that including facet-level information increases the predictive validity of personality assessment, but not for each outcome. Hence, it is important to perform a personality-based job analysis that tell you which traits and facets are relevant in a particular occupation before selecting a specific personality measure.

Regarding rater perspectives, the majority of studies on personality to date rely on self-reports only. Hence, we can assume that the personality assessments used in these studies reflect not only individual differences in one's "true" personality, but also individual differences in the way that individuals perceive and construct their personality system. The Johari window, a popular counseling psychology tool named after its creators Joseph Luft and Harrington Ingram (Luft, 1961; Luft & Ingham, 1955), offers one way to expand available rater perspectives by combining ratings of both self-respondents and observers and hence merging knowledge "known" and "unknown" to self-respondents as well as "known" and "unknown" to observers. This creates a four-quadrant grid (see Figure 1) which serves as the basis for McAbee & Connelly's (2016) Trait-Reputation-Identity (TRI) Model.

The "trait" quadrant represents information that is available to both the self and observers. "Reputation" describes the part of personality that is perceivable by others but unknown to the self. The "Identity" quadrant reflects knowledge only known to the self and unknown to observers. Finally, some information may remain "unknown" or unperceivable to both the self and observers. By crossing different rater perspectives on one's personality, the TRI model disentangles personality ratings into three components: Trait, Reputation, and Identity (and error). Personality researchers should keep in mind that, although (dynamic) trait factors account for substantial variance in personality assessment, a considerate portion of variance can also be ascribed to reputation and identity factors and gaining insight into these factors might be interesting as well (McAbee & Connelly, 2016).

Figure 1

The four quadrants of the Trait-Reputation-Identity Model



Note. The Trait-Reputation-Identity (TRI, McAbee & Connelly, 2016) model builds on the ideas underlying the Johari window.

Considerations

More and more organizational research is dedicated to personality at work, and personality tests have increasingly become part of personnel selection and development procedures. However, there are a number of considerations regarding personality at work and the use of personality measurement tools in an organizational context. Even though personality turns out to be a consistent predictor of work performance, the predictive validity of personality on performance in meta-analytical research is moderate. One potential way to advance the field of personality research, it to move beyond a purely trait-based approach that focuses on stable between-person differences. Instead, personality should be conceptualized as a dynamic system that considers situational influences and the interplay between person and situation (e.g., behavioral signatures or situation contingencies).

A shift in the conceptualization of personality also requires a shift in the ways to assess and measure personality: more research on person-situation interactions and assessment methods that allow to capture them might be useful. One way to achieve this is to step away from relying solely on single-source self-reports and adopt more multi-rater designs because the

raters can be selected such that they observe the focal individual in different situations (e.g., the manager, subordinates, and colleagues of the individual). It is also possible to incorporate other data collection methods, such as behavioral observations in assessment center settings, data collections that use experience sampling method data, and/or multi-wave or longitudinal assessments.

Lastly, the use of personality measurement in the workplace should not happen without acknowledging and considering potential limitations. Five-factor model assessment, being developed by studying young college students from western, educated, industrialized, rich, and developed countries (WEIRD countries), might include some items that are culturally specific and therefore might not work in the same way in different cultures. This might, in turn, lead to organizations being more inclined to hire individuals from WEIRD countries, thereby limiting or even neglecting an organizations diversity and inclusion efforts (Laajaj et al., 2019).

Considering these limitations in future research and practice offers the potential to further advance our understanding of personality and individual differences, and, in turn, potentially bring us one step closer to accurately predicting (work) behavior.

References

Allport, G. W. (1937). *Personality: A Psychological Interpretation*. Henry Holt and Company. http://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.155561

Ashton, M. C., Lee, K., & de Vries, R. E. (2014). The HEXACO Honesty-Humility, Agreeableness, and Emotionality Factors: A Review of Research and Theory. *Personality and Social Psychology Review, 18*(2), 139–152. https://doi.org/10.1177/1088868314523838

Beckmann, N., & Wood, R. E. (2020). Dynamic personality at work. In Y. Griep & S. D. Hansen (Eds.), *Handbook on the temporal dynamics of organizational behavior* (pp. 197-220). Edward Elgar Publishing. https://doi.org/10.4337/9781788974387

Bleidorn, W., Hopwood, C. J., Back, M. D., Denissen, J. J. A., Hennecke, M., Hill, P. L., Jokela, M., Kandler, C., Lucas, R. E., Luhmann, M., Orth, U., Roberts, B. W., Wagner, J., Wrzus, C., & Zimmermann, J. (2021). Personality trait stability and change. *Personality Science, 2*, 1–20. https://doi.org/10.5964/ps.6009

Costa, P. T., & McCrae, R. R. (1992a). Four ways five factors are basic. *Personality and Individual Differences, 13*(6), 653–665. https:// doi .org/ 10.1016/ 0191 -8869(92)90236 -I

Costa, P. T., & McCrae, R. R. (1992b). *Revised NE0 Personality Inventory (NEO-PI-R) and NE0 Five-Factor Inventory (NEO-FFI) Professional Manual.* Psychological Assessment Resources.

Costa, P. T., & McCrae, R. R. (2008). The Revised NEO Personality Inventory (NEO-PI-R). In G. Boyle, G. Matthews & D. Saklofske (Eds), *The SAGE Handbook of Personality Theory and Assessment: Volume 2—Personality Measurement and Testing* (pp. 179–198). SAGE. https:// doi .org/ 10 .4135/ 9781849200479.n9

Fleeson, W. (2001). Toward a Structure- and Process-Integrated View of Personality: Traits as Density Distributions of States. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 80*(6), 1011–1027.

Gosling, S. D., Rentfrow, P. J., & Swann, W. B. (2003). A very brief measure of the Big-Five personality domains. *Journal of Research in Personality, 37*(6), 504–528. https:// doi .org/ 10.1016/ S0092 -6566(03)00046 -1

Hogan, R., & Foster, J. (2016). Rethinking personality. *International Journal of Personality Psychology, 2,* 37–43.

Hudson, N. W., & Fraley, R. C. (2015). Volitional personality trait change: Can people choose to change their personality traits? *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 109*(3), 490–507. https:// doi .org/ 10 .1037/ pspp0000021

Laajaj, R., Macours, K., Pinzon Hernandez, D. A., Arias, O., Gosling, S. D., Potter, J., Rubio-Codina, M., & Vakis, R. (2019). Challenges to capture the big five personality traits in non-WEIRD populations. *Science Advances, 5*(7), 1-13. https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.aaw5226

Luft, J. (1961) The Johari Window: A graphic model of awareness in interpersonal relations. *Human Relations Training News, 5* (1), 6–7.

Luft, J., & Ingham, H. (1955). The Johari window: A graphic model of interpersonal awareness. Paper presented at the Proceedings of the Western Training Laboratory in Group Development, Los Angeles, CA: UCLA Extension Office.

McAbee, S. T., & Connelly, B. S. (2016). A multi-rater framework for studying personality: The trait-reputation-identity model. *Psychological Review, 123*(5), 569–591. https://doi.org/10.1037/rev0000035

Mischel, W., & Shoda, Y. (1995). A Cognitive-Affective System Theory of Personality: Reconceptualizing Situations, Dispositions, Dynamics, and Invariance in Personality Structure. *Psychological Review, 102*(2), 246–268.

Ritz, J., Woods, S. A., Wille, B., Woo, S. E., Nübold, A., Beckmann, N., Dalal, R. S., Galic, Z., Wiernik, B., Tett, R. P., Pickett, J., & Christiansen, N. (2023). Personality at work. *Personality Science, 4*, 1–22. https:// doi .org/ 10.5964/ ps .7045

Saucier, G. & Goldberg, L. (2003). The Structure of Personality Attributes. In M. R. Barrick & A. M. Ryan. (Eds). *Personality and Work: Reconsidering the Role of Personality in Organizations* (1st ed., pp. 1-29). John Wiley & Sons, Inc.

Shaffer, J. A., & Postlethwaite, B. E. (2012). A Matter of Context: A Meta-Analytic Investigation of the Relative Validity of Contextualized and Noncontextualized Personality Measures. *Personnel Psychology, 65*(3), 445–494. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1744-6570.2012.01250.x

Sosnowska, J., Kuppens, P., De Fruyt, F., & Hofmans, J. (2019). A dynamic systems approach to personality: The Personality Dynamics (PersDyn) model. *Personality and Individual Differences, 144*, 11–18. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.paid.2019.02.013

Soto, C. J., & John, O. P. (2017). The next Big Five Inventory (BFI-2): Developing and assessing a hierarchical model with 15 facets to enhance bandwidth, fidelity, and predictive power. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 113*(1), 117–143. https:// doi .org/ 10.1037/ pspp0000096

Woods, S. A., & Anderson, N. R. (2016). Toward a periodic table of personality: Mapping personality scales between the five-factor model and the circumplex model. *Journal of Applied Psychology, 101*(4), 582–604. https://doi.org/10.1037/apl0000062